

profit. Even today, Dr. Franklin's idealistic eighteenth-century version of entrepreneurship is inspirational. When he reminded us that "energy and persistence conquer all things," Franklin was likely describing his own motivations to create and to succeed, using Schumpeter's formulation, for the joy of creating, of exercising one's energy and ingenuity, the will to conquer, and the joy of a good battle.

Franklin's creation of a mutual insurance company was the classic example of his community-minded approach to entrepreneurship. In the eighteenth century, fire was a major and ever-present threat to cities. In 1736, when barely 30 years of age, Franklin responded to that threat by founding the Union Fire Company, literally a bucket brigade that protected the homes of its subscribers. In a short time, other Philadelphia fire companies had formed and begun to compete with one another, so in April 1752, Franklin joined with his colleagues in founding the Philadelphia Contributionship, which continues today as the oldest property insurance company in the United States. And he didn't stop there. He also founded a library, an academy and college, a hospital, and a learned society—none for his personal enrichment, all for the benefit of his community. Not bad!

Like many entrepreneurs, Franklin was also an inventor. Once again, his goal was to improve the community's quality of life. Among other devices, he created the lightning rod and the Franklin stove (to say nothing of bifocals and swim fins). He made no attempt to patent the lightning rod for his own profit, and he declined the offer by the governor of the Commonwealth for a patent on his Franklin stove, the "Pennsylvania fireplace," his 1744 invention that revolutionized the efficiency of home heating with great benefit to the public at large. Benjamin Franklin believed that "Knowledge is not the personal property of its discoverer, but the common property of all. As we enjoy great advantages from the inventions of others, we should be glad of an opportunity to serve others by any invention of ours, and this we should do freely and generously."

As the first decade of the twenty-first century comes to a close, Franklin's noble eighteenth-century values stand in bold contrast to the bitter patent wars of today, to the obscene salary demands of the